



Development Shishir Adhikari.

Naskar, who will oversee the project, says that it would be a direct contact programme. "Earlier, money transfer used to take more than two years' time. In the first phase, we have identified 900 km of the total 3,500 km of embankments needed. These embankments had been built during the zamindari regime and were in a state of disrepair. It was only

tive literature at Jadavpur University, has been visiting the Aila-struck areas on a private relief mission. He, however, has a different take on the use of concrete embankments. "With global warming, cyclones such as Aila will become more frequent. The villagers are yet to recoup even by half. I shudder to think what will happen should something like the Aila strike with vengeance again," he says. Naskar, on his part, has pointed out that concrete embankments would not be encouraged. "Aila has taught us a lesson and we are not going to do anything that

BHATTACHARYA (LEFT) HAS MUCH TO ANSWER FOR WHILE BANERJEE HAS ALL THE QUESTIONS AND THE SUPPORT



DOES NOT STOP BANERJEE FROM PLAYING THE OPPOSITION LEADER IN KOLKATA.

Back to the Wall

- Bhattacharya revamps his Cabinet. Anisur Rahman and Anadi Sahu are given Panchayat and Labour ministries.
- The Left Government announces that the land for new embankments to be built in the Aila-hit Sunderbans would be purchased directly from the farmers.
- In Kolkata, 60,000 polluting vehicles are taken off the roads after a court order. The state Government makes sure that the order is followed strictly.

during the 1960s that the government took over the maintenance," he says, revealing that a sum of Rs 6,800 crore will be earmarked for the project and the work would start soon after the Cabinet approval. "The money offered to the farmers would be the prevalent market rate or even above. Middlemen won't be involved," he adds.

The state Government is also planning a permanent land zone for embankments after buying land from the villagers. "A lot of agricultural land is available in the Sunderbans. Once the poor farmers get the money, they are not going to be unemployed. They will not even be displaced and can buy land elsewhere," says Naskar. Samantak Das, a reader of compara-

will affect the 45 lakh villagers in the area adversely," he said.

The villagers who were used to giving away their land out of panic and recurring natural disasters are happy now. Hemanta Mondal, who lives in Gosaba and runs a grocery shop few kilometres away from Sunderbans, says that if the villagers get good money and if proper embankments are built, it would be a boon for them. The project offers a ray of hope to the villagers. The promises it makes show that the Left is now beginning to shed some of the arrogance of power. It is the same arrogance that had alienated the Left from its traditional rural votebank that was largely responsible for its uninterrupted reign of three decades. ■